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A revolution is most commonly defined as the overthrow of the ruler by the ruled or a radical, sudden and complete change. Should you trace the growth of modern India over its 60 years as a free country, you could confidently argue that India has in fact been the hotbed of its own distinct and radical revolutions.

In a relatively short lifespan as a free nation, India has been transformed as a society by events in its politics, business and popular culture. At the time they occurred, the events would have been considered random happenings in the life of a nation. Looking back, these moments have been nothing short of revolutionary. For 60 years, India lived through a series of revolutions, from violent to peaceful, from the ubiquitous and much-celebrated to the silent and the invisible.

With INDIA TODAY, I have been a witness as well as a part of the dramatic changes in the country in the past 32 years. The print media has grown stronger, more vibrant and is rightly recognised as the fourth pillar of India's democracy. Open skies have led to an explosion in the electronic media and its own 'new journalism'. As I look around, I find India's pace of change only accelerating.

What else could explain a country whose purchasing power doubled in 2003 from what it was in 1999, which has among the largest networks of banks in the world and houses the research bases of 125 of the world's top *Fortune 500* companies?

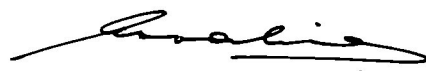
When India won its Independence, few gave it a chance. The country was too large, too poor and too beset with problems to survive. At best it would fall apart into separate states, at worst destroy itself. Nothing of the kind happened. India is bigger than before. The country we live in today is the result of its economic forces and its revolutions, big and small. The world is taking note of India's large middle class market, its English-speaking workforce and its energetic business community. In 1990, even India's harshest critic V.S. Naipaul had observed in his book *India: A Million Mutinies Now* that "there was in India now what didn't exist 200 years before: a central will, a central intellect, a national idea. The Indian Union was greater than the sum of its parts."

For the third and penultimate special issue around the theme of India at Sixty, we decided to track the life of a nation through the impact of its change. These revolutions have put food on our table, water in our homes, girls in schools and safeguards in our ballot boxes. They have changed the way we live and travel, what we eat, how we entertain ourselves and even how we pray.

This issue, put together by Executive Editor Kaveree Bamzai and her energetic team of Chitra Subramaniam, Purvi Malhotra, Deepika Khatri and Bushra Ahmed, is made up of a combination of invited essays from leading scholars such as Sumit Ganguly and Tarun Khanna, reportage from our correspondents and the occasional memoir from pioneers such as Verghese Kurien and Sunil Mittal.

Our correspondents travelled across the country to tell the stories of these revolutions. Among others, Managing Editor Shankkar Aiyar discovered how the life of Mahabir Mahto in Jharkhand was transformed by a single road connecting his village to the wider world. Associate Editor Ramesh Vinayak found four survivors of the Khalistan movement. Assistant Editor Priya Sahgal located 78-year-old Pratima Kaushik who, as a 13-year-old, was caught distributing pamphlets against the British.

We live in a remarkable country, capable of great outrage and great surprise. India is many things, but it is never static. For all its ancient, unchanging rhythms, India is always changing. Underneath its calm, placid surface, there are always revolutions afoot. It has been our endeavour to capture them and bring them to you in the most memorable way.


(Aron Purie)